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Strategy Is My Love Language: Building Smarter, Not Harder

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> *Structure is not the enemy of freedom. It's the scaffolding that holds your vision in place.*

What They Don't Tell You About Strategy

When I was nine, I remember following my mum to the market to buy goods for her provision store. After everything was stacked and paid for, my mum signaled to a barrow pusher to help us move the load across the road to where she parked.

But the person who came forward wasn't a man.

It was a woman. Thin, older, in a faded wrapper. She gripped the handles with a kind of practiced strength.

It caught me off guard. I tugged at my mum's hand and whispered, "Mummy, it's a woman."

She glanced at the woman, then at me. "She's working," she said. "She's strong. She's not stealing. And one day, it'll pay off."

The woman smiled. She had heard us. And somehow, I think she believed it

So did I.

For years after, I held onto that idea – that if you work hard, especially if it's uncomfortable or painful, success will come. That struggle always produces results. That effort is the currency of breakthrough.

But growing up taught me something different.

I saw people work until their backs gave out. I saw mothers sell food in the sun for years and still borrow money to pay rent. I saw business owners burn out not because they lacked passion, but because they had no support, no system, no structure.

And when I started my own business journey, I felt it too. That constant spinning. That pressure to do everything manually. That guilt when rest felt like laziness.

No one had taught me strategy.

Not in the formal way. Not even in the “common sense” way. Just work. Just try. Just hustle and pray.

We grow up hearing a loud version of entrepreneurship. Rise-and-grind mantras. 18-hour days. Burnout disguised as ambition. And in many African communities, the pressure to succeed comes wrapped in urgency: "You better make it count. You’re the first. Don’t waste the opportunity."

But what if the most radical thing an entrepreneur could do... is build slowly? Strategically? On purpose?

Hustle Was Loud. Strategy Is Peace.

When I got into university, I thought I’d try my hand at business. I started selling wigs — affordable ones, nothing too fancy. I really believed it would work. I’d done the calculations, sourced a few pieces, and was sure the profit would start rolling in.

But what I didn’t know was that business isn’t just hard work and showing up. I ended up giving some wigs out on credit and using a few myself. I forgot the price of others. And because I had no system to track anything, I just kept saying “yes” and trusting it would sort itself out.

It didn’t.

That business crashed before it even found its legs. And I remember thinking, maybe entrepreneurship just wasn’t for me. Maybe it’s only for people with more capital or luck, or time to figure it out.

Fast forward to life after university. Reality set in, and so did bills. I knew I had to do something. I had always been a decent writer, so freelancing made sense. It was flexible. Scalable. Supposedly easier to manage.

But after a few months, I found myself burnt out again.

I was writing constantly, delivering quality work, getting paid, but somehow, my money disappeared as fast as it came. I wasn’t tracking anything. Not my time. Not my rates. Not my expenses. I was working hard, but I wasn’t building anything.

I started joining communities of young entrepreneurs. Listening more. Asking better questions. And over and over, I kept hearing the same words: Systems. Strategy. Intention.

Then I came across a quote by Jim Rohn that summed it up perfectly:

> *“Success is 20% skills and 80% strategy. You might know how to succeed, but more importantly, what’s your plan to succeed?”*

I started building processes. I set up automated client flows on HoneyBook, tracked my income with Notion templates, and used scheduling tools like Calendly to protect my time. The more I structured, the more I breathed.

As Lawrence Bossidy, former CEO of Honeywell, aptly put it: “Execution is the ability to mesh strategy with reality, align people with goals, and achieve the promised results.” That line reminded me that strategy isn’t just about planning; it's about the systems and processes that bring those plans to life.

Strategy Isn’t Just for the Rich

There’s this myth that strategy is for the well-funded. That systems and structure are luxuries. But the truth is: they’re survival tools. Especially for underfunded, overextended Black-owned businesses.

You don’t need a $20k consultant to:

- Set boundaries with your time

- Create tiered pricing that reflects your energy

- Automate your booking or fulfillment process

- Schedule rest just like revenue-generating tasks

In fact, the earlier you start thinking like a CEO, the better. Not to mimic corporate capitalism, but to protect your creativity from chaos.

> *“Structure is not the enemy of freedom. It is the scaffolding that holds your vision in place.”*

Look at Diarrha N'Diaye-Mbaye, founder of Ami Colé. Her clean beauty brand didn’t just happen. She blended strategy into every corner — from how the products were formulated to how the story was told. Her focus wasn’t mass scale overnight. It was strategic growth through community trust. Her story here.

Systems Are Self-Respect

I used to think I wasn’t "big enough" for systems. But I was wrong. Systems are not a flex. They are a boundary.

When I started:

- Using Airtable to track content timelines

- Pre-writing email templates for client onboarding

- Documenting my service packages clearly

...my stress halved. My confidence doubled.

And I noticed something: strategic structure made me trust myself more. No more winging it. No more people-pleasing with blurry rates. I showed up clearer, calmer, and more credible.

Pauleanna Reid, a writer and entrepreneur I deeply admire, once shared that her turning point was when she started documenting everything: SOPs, email flows, delegation strategies. She said it wasn't about building a machine — it was about building freedom. That changed the way I saw my own process.

You Deserve to Build Without Burning

Strategy is care. It's foresight. It's saying: I believe this idea enough to protect it. To organize it. To build systems that let me sleep, let me live.

And it's not about perfection. You will adjust. You will tweak. You'll outgrow some systems. But the decision to build on purpose — not just on pressure — will always lead to deeper success.

Even Issa Rae, in her recent ventures — from Sienna Naturals to her stake in Hilltop Coffee — has moved intentionally. She's spoken about building ownership, not just output. Watch her speak on sustainable business and long-term play. It's not loud, but it's lasting.

If you're reading this and still building, still doubting, still trying: this is your permission to slow down and strategize. Not later. Now.

Not because you have something to prove.

But because you have something worth preserving.

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